Table column widths

By default glu sizes table columns automatically: each column ends up as wide as its content needs. A `width` on a `<td>` or `<th>` overrides that measurement, so the layout stays put however long the text turns out.

An even split that stays even

The classic case is a signature block. Both cells declare `width: 50%`, so the right-hand column starts at the same position in both tables even though they hold different amounts of text.

Place, date	For the client

Berlin, 3 March 2026	For the contractor, represented by the managing director

Leave the widths out and each column shrinks to its own content, so the two blocks drift apart and the signature lines no longer align.

Percentages and absolute lengths

A percentage resolves against the width of the table, an absolute length is taken as it is. A percentage is therefore only as meaningful as the table it refers to: a table shrinks to its content unless told otherwise, so the stylesheet sets `table { width: 100% }` first.

25 percent	75 percent, so this column is three times as wide as its neighbour.

Exactly 4 cm	Whatever is left over: declaring a width for only some columns is fine, the undeclared ones share what remains.

Sizing a Markdown table from CSS

Pipe tables have nowhere to put a `style` attribute, so their columns are sized from the stylesheet with `nth-child`. Wrapping the table in a `<div class="terms">` gives the rule something to hook onto: the table is a descendant, not the element carrying the class. Name `th` and `td` alike, or the header row keeps its automatic width.

```
.terms table th:nth-child(1), .terms table td:nth-child(1) { width: 22% }
```

Property	Value	Effect
`width`	percentage	Share of the table width.
`width`	length	Fixed column width, e.g. `4cm` or `120pt`.
`width`	omitted	Column is measured from its content.

What the width really promises

A declared width is the column's preferred *and* minimum size.

Situation	Outcome
Content needs more room than declared	It wraps, and is never clipped: a word too long to fit still widens the column.
Widths add up to more than 100%	All of them scale down proportionally. Two columns asking for 80% each end up with 50% apiece.
Width on a cell spanning columns	Ignored: it belongs to no single column. Declare it on a row without `colspan` instead.